The Five Motivations

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By: Snorka, edited by: matcha_tea

Introduction

As server owners and server theorists, our goal is to maximize fun, but that is a nebulous goal with many disparate ways to accomplish it. This article's aim is to classify the different reasons people have fun on Minecraft servers so future theories can focus on maximizing certain motivations rather than just aiming for the subjective target of "fun."

There are the five motivations: accomplishment, creativity, discovery, connection, and domination. Each of them is present in everyone, just to different degrees. Of course, players also have their own preferences within these categories and separate from them (e.g. someone might prefer building in a modern style or a fantasy one, but both fit within the creativity motivation), but any time you are having fun on a server, it does fit into one or more of the motivations.

I. Accomplishment

This is perhaps the broadest category. Players may feel accomplishment after completing something difficult – the main challenge with adding accomplishment to a server is weighing difficulty so you add accomplishment without making the game frustrating. The kind of challenge players must overcome can come in many forms: combat challenges obviously come to mind, but building farms and other redstone machines is another common thing players do to feel accomplished. The first three motivations can all be achieved in singleplayer, but accomplishment is often even better when you can show off what you have done to your servermates. When optimizing for accomplishment, make sure that players' accomplishments can benefit others!

II. Creativity

A big chunk of Minecraft players are builders first and foremost. Creativity is the motivation that explains that. Again, the main reason to build on a server instead of a solo world is so other people can see what you built, so make sure that is possible. When optimizing for creativity, you want to make most desirable building materials easy to obtain. Although you can get accomplishment from building with netherite or beacons, that is no more creatively stimulating than building with cheaper stuff. Another way that accomplishment can look like creativity is when building is mechanically useful. Making effective fortifications or prisons is an accomplishment, decorating them is creativity. Keep that in mind!

III. Discovery

People like seeing new things. All the structures and biomes to explore in vanilla contribute to the experience of someone who cares a lot about discovery, but there is only so much to see there. On a server, ignoring any mods that add more things to see, players can experience discovery by traveling and coming across what other players have built. To optimize for discovery, make sure that is possible! If griefing is allowed, builders need to hide their builds, which harms the discovery experience. Also, concentrating builds in certain areas can make them easier to find. There's also a less obvious element of discovering game mechanics (again, this is largely through mods for regular server players) and social dynamics. You can absolutely get a sense of discovery through observing a server's economy, politics, and wars.

IV. Connection

This is the first of the server-exclusive motivations. People like spending time with their friends! When optimizing for connection, make sure it is easy to meet up with friends (such as with tp commands) and to make new ones (this could be a whole theory in itself). Another aspect of connection is that people like working together with a group, even if the group are not all close friends. Pre-established or naturally arising factions are great for this, as well as any content that is only possible (or much easier) by doing in a group. Domination: This motivation is all about feeling superior to other people. This can come from winning in competitions, like PvP or minigames, and it can also come from being in charge of a group or faction. Including ranks is great for domination-motivated players. This is absolutely one of the more dangerous motivations to optimize for, though. For one person to win, other people have to lose, and many discouraging moments when you get killed or griefed come from other players chasing domination. But it is still a major way people have fun, especially in online games.